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What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **Some of the biggest** Obamacare companies are seeking hefty premium increases for 2027, often for the second year in a row. **A1**
- ◆ **Global oil prices** surged 5.2% in their steepest one-day jump since May after Trump said the truce with Iran is over. The Dow and S&P 500 fell 1.1% and 0.3%, respectively, while the Nasdaq rose 0.2%. **B1**
- ◆ **Blue Origin**, Jeff Bezos' space company, is working on a \$10 billion funding round that would value the company at \$130 billion, a person familiar with the matter said. **B1**
- ◆ **A Trump family crypto** venture that channeled more than half a billion dollars to the family is in talks to sell its core business to blockchain tech company Perpetuals.com. **B1**
- ◆ **Burger King restaurant** operator Minor Food is planning an IPO that could become Singapore's largest food-and-beverage listing in years, according to people familiar with the matter. **B3**
- ◆ **Air Canada ventured** outside the company and country for its new CEO. **B3**
- ◆ **China's auto sales** remained weak in June, with retail sales of passenger cars slumping 20.2% in the first half. **B3**
- ◆ **Apple plans to spend** more than \$30 billion with Broadcom in the next five years as it ramps its investment in U.S.-made chips. **B4**
- ◆ **China said it has found** "security backdoor vulnerabilities" in Anthropic's popular Claude Code. **B4**

Worldwide

- ◆ **Trump said he believed** his ceasefire deal with Iran was over shortly before the U.S. launched more strikes on the country as retaliation for attacks on ships in the Strait of Hormuz. **A1**
- ◆ **The president said he** supported Ukraine's strikes deep inside Russia, calling it an escalation that could help end the long war. **A1, A5**
- ◆ **Democratic nominee** Graham Platner said he would halt his campaign for Senate in Maine, after he was publicly accused of sexual assault. He continued to deny wrongdoing. **A2**
- ◆ **A federal judge ordered** Trump to pay the \$5 million in damages to writer E. Jean Carroll after the Supreme Court declined to hear his appeal of the defamation and sexual-abuse verdict. **A3**
- ◆ **An Idaho mother** who said her twin toddlers died after getting routine vaccinations has been indicted on charges of murder, accused of suffocating them. **A3**
- ◆ **A former Wisconsin judge** was spared prison after being convicted of obstructing federal agents seeking to arrest an immigrant. **A3**
- ◆ **Just under half** of Americans say capitalism is working very well or even somewhat well, down from 60% who said so about a decade ago, according to a new Wall Street Journal-NORC survey. **A4**
- ◆ **The Trump administration** is pressuring Cuba's government by zeroing in on one of its few remaining sources of hard currency: the doctors and nurses it deploys abroad. **A7**

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Ukrainian medical workers inspect the body of a person who was killed by a Russian missile strike in the city of Kharkiv.

Trump, in Shift, Backs Ukraine Striking Targets Deep in Russia

President says he will consider letting Kyiv manufacture Patriot missile interceptors

President Trump said he supported Ukraine striking targets deep inside Russian territory, calling it an escalation that could help end the war. The comments mark his strongest praise yet of Ukraine's military strategy and deal a significant blow to Russia's efforts to keep Trump on its side in talks to end the war. In a marked contrast to past meetings between the two lead-

ers, Trump opened his session with President Volodymyr Zelensky on Wednesday by offering warm words and fresh promises of military cooperation with Ukraine, providing a major boon for Kyiv and its supporters in Europe. Trump praised Ukraine's bravery, signaled he would consider granting Kyiv a license to produce U.S. Patriot missile interceptors and said he would consider traveling to Kyiv at the right time in peace talks. Ukraine has run critically low on Patriot missiles, which have been used to intercept Russian ballistic missiles. The shortage left its capital and

By Robbie Gramer, Anastasiia Malenko and Brian Schwartz

other cities exposed during deadly large-scale Russian attacks this summer. The path from licensing rights to standing up production lines for Patriot interceptors could take years, and Trump didn't offer more specifics on the plan. "It's an escalation, but it's also an escalation that could help lead to an end," Trump said of backing Ukrainian strikes deep inside Russian territory. He spoke during a session with the Ukrainian presi-

dent at the NATO summit in Ankara, Turkey, on Wednesday. Ukraine is also making a fresh push with the Trump administration to obtain Starlink access over Russia as it seeks to expand its strikes on energy and military infrastructure deep inside the country, officials familiar with the matter said. Zelensky discussed the matter with U.S. lawmakers and other allied officials ahead of his meeting with Trump on *Please turn to page A5*

◆ **NATO allies relieved to avoid clash at summit....** A5
◆ **Hard-hit Kyiv enclave stands tough.....** A5

Air-Bag Parts Are Killing Drivers

Regulators warn about faulty inflaters marked as made by Chinese company

By RYAN FELTON

Eui Seok Kang lost control of his Chevrolet Malibu in torrential rain late one night in October 2023, spun sideways across two lanes of a Texas road and was struck by a pickup truck. When his air bag deployed, it tore apart his jaw. "I couldn't breathe, I felt like something was stuck in my throat," Kang recalled in

an interview. He lost half of his lower jaw, most of his lower teeth and some upper teeth. Over the next month, he underwent three surgeries, including for an infection and facial reconstruction. The air bag, it turned out, had been purchased on eBay and installed by the Texas dealership that sold him the used car. When he crashed, it sent metal shards flying into *Please turn to page A8*

Rhode Island Is at War Over a Wall

Fix for sinking hole at golf course stokes old debate

By OWEN TUCKER-SMITH

Paddling up Narragansett Bay, a kayaker spotted a strange new development between the Quiddnessett Country Club and the sea: a heaping pile of rocks. Then all hell broke loose. First came the phone calls: the kayaker alerted activists, who informed the state, which dispatched a team of investigators to inspect the stone structure. The wall, two football fields long and 20 feet tall, stood between the 14th hole of the club's golf course and the water. State officials, con- *Please turn to page A10*

Obamacare Insurers Seek Hefty Rate Rises

By ANNA WILDE MATHEWS

Rates for many Affordable Care Act plans rose by double digits this year. Insurers want to do the same next year. Some of the biggest Obamacare companies are seeking hefty premium increases for 2027, often for the second year in a row. In Washington state, Centene is asking for a 28% increase, after boosting rates by 35% in 2026. Blue Cross and Blue Shield of Illinois wants 15%—on top of a 28% increase this year. "It is a stunning jump" when you add both years together, said Cynthia Cox, senior vice president at KFF, a health-research nonprofit. At the request of The Wall Street Journal, KFF analyzed the rate requests for the largest ACA plans by enrollment in 15 states where insurers' 2027 filings have already be-

INSIDE



U.S. NEWS
A WSJ poll finds America is in a dark mood as it marks 250th birthday. **A4**

Platner Halts Maine Senate Campaign

By TARINI PARTI

Democratic nominee Graham Platner said he would abandon his campaign for the Senate in Maine, ending a run for office that had drawn broad grassroots support but was plagued by a growing series of controversies. Platner's decision came just days after he was publicly accused by a former romantic partner of sexual assault, which he denied. The move allows the state Democratic Party to find a replacement on the November ballot to face incumbent GOP Sen. Susan

Collins, in what Democrats consider a must-win seat in their fight to take back the chamber. Platner announced his exit in a video Wednesday night, in which he blamed the media and political establishment for acting as "judge, jury and executioner" and continued to deny wrongdoing. In the 11-minute video, Platner said he was targeted by Democratic forces that oppose his brand of populist politics and were desperate to get him out of the race. The sexual-assault accusation prompted top *Please turn to page A2*

Costco Cashier Feels Like a Million Bucks

By SARAH NASSAUER

TUCSON, Ariz.—Costco cashier Tony Barzar unloaded his lunch in the breakroom, clocked in and headed for the checkout, just as he has for much of the past four decades. That day, like most days, the 60-year-old Barzar was assigned to the self-checkout area, a cluster of six registers. At 9:02 a.m., the first shoppers were ready to ring themselves up. "Right here, ma'am!" Barzar said, gesturing for a customer in line to move to an open register. "How ya doing today, sir? Find everything all right?" he said to another as he circled the registers with a scanning gun. Long-tenured workers like Barzar are Costco's secret weapon. They are reliable and experienced, able to speed shoppers through a checkout line and serve as mentors to

newer workers, passing down the company's unique culture, Costco executives said. Barzar's pay and benefits reflect his value to the company. He earns \$32.90 an hour, and the holdings in his 401(k) have boosted his retirement savings to more than \$1 million, he said. His Costco-sponsored healthcare has a regular visit copay of \$15, and a specialty visit copay of \$25, below the national average. In 2009, Barzar's family bought a three-bedroom, two-bath house with a pool, and they have traveled to Europe twice over the past decade. As a younger person, "I didn't think me and my family would reach where we sit now," he said. "I could retire, but what would I do? Costco has been good to me." Costco has long paid more than most U.S. retailers to *Please turn to page A4*